THE RIDER · No.14

BUSINESS · THE HOST OF THE NIGHT

YOU SET THE CLOCK.

THE DJ IS THE HOST.

Studies of music in bars and restaurants keep finding the same thing: what's playing changes how long people stay and how the room moves. In most venues one person has their hand on that dial all night. You. This edition shows what the research found, and gives you the words and the sheet to own that power in your next fee conversation.

WHAT'S IN THIS EDITION

01	**THE CASE**	What bar and restaurant studies found about music, time and drinks
02	**THE ROOM IS CHANGING**	How nights out are shifting in the US, Britain and India
03	**THE HOST**	Five ways you already run the night
04	**THE HOST'S QUESTIONS**	Five questions to ask before you quote
05	**THE NIGHT MAP**	Map their night, plus four fee-talk lines
06	**BY CONTEXT**	Club, cocktail bar, wedding and sangeet, corporate
07	**LIMITS · GO DEEPER**	What this doesn't mean, and the sources

> This is a working business guide, not financial advice. The studies here measure background music in bars and restaurants, not DJs on dancefloors. Use it to think, then make your own call.

Compiled by Vic Naik · The Vic Fix · 19 years, 18+ countries.

01 · THE CASE

MUSIC MOVES TIME.
YOU MOVE THE MUSIC.

The evidence is small and some of it is old. Here it is, kept separate from our reading of it.

WHAT THE RESEARCH FOUND

1. Louder music, faster drinking (one small study).
In two French bars in 2008, researchers played the same music at two volumes to 40 young men drinking beer. At 88 dB they finished a glass in about **11.5 minutes**, against about **14.5** at 72 dB, and ordered more drinks (3.4 against 2.6).

Guéguen et al., Alcoholism: Clinical & Experimental Research, 2008. Figures as reported in coverage of the paper.

It's one small study, and the lead researcher's other work has faced data-quality questions. This paper isn't retracted. Treat it as a hint, not a law.

2. Slower music, longer stays.
A classic 1986 study in one US restaurant found slower background music kept diners at the table longer, and linked it to more spent at the bar.

Milliman, Journal of Consumer Research, 1986.

3. But in 2024, the money part didn't hold.
A field test in a Tel Aviv restaurant tried it again across 282 tables. Slow music (72 BPM or under) kept diners about **80 minutes**; fast music (94 BPM or over) about **57**. The bill? No difference. Whether a table ordered alcohol moved the bill far more than the music did.

Malcman, Azar, Shavit & Rosenboim, Behavioral Sciences, 2024.

4. Tempo can change sipping speed.
In a lab study, 40 students rating a soda drank it faster when the music was fast.

McElrea & Standing, Perceptual and Motor Skills, 1992. Soda, not alcohol; a lab, not a bar.

OUR READING

Across separate studies, volume seems to push drinking pace and tempo seems to push time in the seat. No single study tested both, and none involved a DJ. But the pattern is clear enough to say this: **music isn't background. It shapes how long a room stays and how it moves.** And the person choosing the music all night is you.

02 · THE ROOM IS CHANGING

THE ROOM IS CHANGING. THE HOST ADAPTS.

How people go out is shifting, and it changes what a venue needs from its DJ. Here's what the numbers say, market by market.

WHAT THE DATA SHOWS

Fewer Americans drink.
Gallup's record-low **54%** of US adults say they drink at all. Among 18–34-year-olds it's **50%**, down from 59% in 2023.

Gallup, Aug 2025; still 54% in Aug 2026.

Britain is losing late-night rooms.
In 2025, late-night bars fell **4.9%** and nightclubs **3.5%**, while cocktail bars grew **4.3%** and craft bars **3.6%** (net site counts, Great Britain). People are going out earlier: the 5–7pm slot now out-earns 7–10pm.

NIQ/NTIA Night Time Economy Market Monitor, Feb 2026.

INDIA RUNS THE OTHER WAY.

Don't import the West's "young people have quit drinking" story. IWSR surveys of affluent urban Indians found legal-age Gen Z drinking participation rose from **60% to 80%** in three years. They're getting choosier per night, not quitting.

IWSR Bevtrac, July 2026. Industry survey; high-income urban respondents only.

THE PATTERN

Wherever you play, nights are shifting: earlier starts, smaller rooms, cocktails over pints in some markets, more young spenders in Indian cities. Every one of those shifts is a change in the night's shape, and shaping the night is your job.

03 · THE HOST

YOU'RE THE HOST.
YOU RUN THE NIGHT.

Great DJs already do all of this. The point is to name it, so the venue sees it too. **This is craft and business interpretation, not research.**

01 **You shape the night.**
Doors, warm-up, the build, the peak, closing. Every club night has a shape, and you're the one drawing it in real time. Ask the venue what their best night looks like, then build it.

02 **Tempo is your time tool.**
Early on, when people are arriving and getting a drink, a patient warm-up lets the room fill. When the floor is the point, you climb. Knowing when is the craft.

03 **A great host looks after the guests.**
Volume is for the room's energy. Keep it there: guests' ears and safety come first, and so do yours (see Rider No.05). Never use the music to speed up drinking, least of all where people are driving home.

04 **Say what you do in their words.**
“I'll build the room” undersells you. “I'll warm up your early crowd and keep them inside, so the floor is packed at your peak hour” is the same skill, described the way an owner values it.

05 **Keep a night log.**
After every gig, note what you saw: rough headcount each hour, when the room peaked, when people left. Three months of that is proof of what you do, and it's worth bringing to every fee talk.

> **THE RULE OF THE ROOM**
>
> **The DJ is the host. You set the clock.**

04 · THE HOST'S QUESTIONS

FIVE QUESTIONS.
ASK THEM BEFORE YOU QUOTE.

Use this on the first call or the walk-through. It takes ten minutes, and it shows the venue you're thinking about their whole night, not just your set.

Venue / night / slot: _____

e.g. Indiranagar club, Saturday, 9pm–1am

01 What does a good night look like for you?

Headcount: _____ Spend per head (rough): _____ Busiest hour: _____

02 Where does the night's money come from?

☐ Mostly bar ☐ Door / tickets ☐ Tables / bottle service

☐ Guest list / promoters ☐ A mix: _____

03 What time does the room fill, peak and empty?

Fills: _____ Peaks: _____ Starts emptying: _____ Last orders: _____

04 Who is the night for?

Age: _____ Regulars or walk-ins: _____ Here to dance or to hang: _____

05 What do you want guests saying on the way out?

_____

_____

The most useful answer you'll get. It tells you the night they want you to build.

WHAT THEY NEED FROM THEIR HOST (FILL IN AFTER THE CALL)

☐ Welcome the early crowd ☐ Keep the early crowd inside ☐ A full room at peak

☐ Bring people in (draw) ☐ A floor they talk about ☐ Other: _____

My one-line pitch in their language:

"I'll _____

so your _____

e.g. "I'll keep your 10pm early crowd in the room so the floor is packed when it peaks at midnight."

05 · THE NIGHT MAP

MAP THEIR NIGHT.
THEN NAME YOUR FEE.

Fill this in from the five questions. One row per phase of their night.

PHASE	TIME	WHAT THE VENUE WANTS	WHAT MY SET DOES
Doors		People arrive and settle in	
Warm-up		The room fills, nobody leaves	
The build		The floor starts to move	
Peak		Energy: the reason they came	
Closing		A good ending, a safe exit	

THE FEE CONVERSATION · FOUR LINES IN THE VENUE'S LANGUAGE

Our scripts. Adapt them to your voice.

01 Open with their night, not your rate.
"Before I quote, tell me what a good Saturday looks like for you."

02 Tie your fee to their outcome.
"My set is built around your peak hour, so the room is full when it matters most."

03 Bring your own evidence.
"Last month at [venue], the floor held from 11 to 1:30. Here's my headcount log."

04 Offer a review point, not a discount.
"Let's do four Saturdays at this fee, then look at the nights together."

BRING TO EVERY FEE TALK

☐ Your night map for their venue ☐ Three nights of your headcount notes ☐ Your plan for their peak hour

06 · BY CONTEXT

SAME IDEA.
FOUR DIFFERENT ROOMS.

A starting framework, not an exhaustive one.

CLUB · DOOR-LED NIGHTS

The door and the floor are the product, and you're the reason people came. Your draw and your floor are the story: bring people, and log it.

Goal: your nights become the venue's best nights.

COCKTAIL BAR / EARLY EVENING

The fastest-growing room in some markets, and the one most likely to want you at 7pm, not midnight. The job is time in the seat: warm, unhurried, never pushing.

Goal: they stay for one more round because the room feels good.

WEDDING / SANGEET

The client pays your fee, and the bar is often open. Pace matters more here, not less: elders, kids and a long night. Never use volume or tempo to speed drinking at a family event.

Goal: the family remembers the floor for years.

CORPORATE

The company is paying for the evening, often with an open bar and colleagues who'll see each other on Monday. Keep the energy social and the volume conversational until the brief says dance.

Goal: the team is still talking about it on Monday.

07 · WHAT THIS DOESN'T MEAN

- **It isn't DJ research.** These studies measured background music in bars and restaurants. No study here involved a DJ, a club or a dancefloor; the host idea is our reading.
- **Slow music doesn't make people spend more.** The 2024 retest found longer stays, not bigger bills.
- **Loud music doesn't reliably make people drink faster.** It was one small 2008 study of 40 young men in two bars.
- **It isn't a reason to push volume or drinks.** A host looks after the guests' ears and safety first.
- **It's not Indian venue data.** Apart from IWSR's survey, we found no reliable Indian data on venue revenue or DJ fees.

GO DEEPER

How Does Background Music Affect Dining Duration, Tips and Bill Amounts in Restaurants?
Malcman, Azar, Shavit & Rosenboim · Behavioral Sciences 14(12), 2024 · open access · doi.org/10.3390/bs14121188

The 2024 retest: time yes, money no.

Sound Level of Environmental Music and Drinking Behavior
Guéguen, Jacob, Le Guellec, Morineau & Lourel · Alcoholism: Clinical & Experimental Research, 2008 · pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/18647281

The bar volume study. Small sample; read the caveats on page 2.

The Influence of Background Music on the Behavior of Restaurant Patrons
Milliman · Journal of Consumer Research 13(2), 1986 · doi.org/10.1086/209068

The classic tempo study the 2024 paper retested.

Fast Music Causes Fast Drinking
McElrea & Standing · Perceptual and Motor Skills 75, 1992 · doi.org/10.2466/pms.1992.75.2.362

A lab study with soda: tempo and sipping speed.

Market data
Gallup, "U.S. Drinking Rate at New Low", 13 Aug 2025, and "Americans' Drinking Remains at Record Low", 20 Aug 2026 · NIQ & NTIA, Night Time Economy Market Monitor, Feb 2026 · IWSR Bevtrac H1 2026 release, 14 Jul 2026

Drinking rates (US), venue mix (Great Britain), young drinkers (urban India).

THE CLOSE

THE DJ IS THE HOST. YOU SET THE CLOCK.

You plan your first three tracks.
You build the bridge.
You read the room.
Now own the whole night.

THE REST OF THE SERIES

No.01 INSURE · Health insurance for working DJs
No.02 RATE · Pricing your work
No.03 TDS · Tax setup for Indian DJs
No.04 CONTRACT · The performance contract
No.05 EARS · Hearing protection
No.06 BRAIN · The neuroscience of DJing
No.07 MOMENTS · Music as memory
No.08 MACHINE · AI-proofing your craft
No.09 2030 · The global DJ economy
No.10 BODY · DJing longevity
No.11 ONE · The first three tracks
No.12 PROPOSAL · The DJ who makes it easy
No.13 TASTE · Your crowd is on autoplay
No.14 CLOCK · You set the clock (this one)

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The Vic Fix · 19 years, 18+ countries · @thevicfix · @djvicofficial

A note on the evidence. The studies and market figures are cited to their sources. Everything about hosting, sets and fee conversations is our craft and business interpretation for working DJs: not a finding, and not tested in clubs.